CORE FALSE BELIEF #19 · RULES I LIVE BY

"I must be in control."

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Where it often comes from

The need for control often grows in chaotic or frightening homes, where a child tried to bring order by managing everything around them. It can also follow trauma, a sudden loss, or a time when things spun out of control. Control can feel like safety. But because so much in life is beyond our control, this belief often leads to anxiety, tension in relationships, and exhaustion.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture teaches that we can make plans, but the Lord directs our steps. James warns against confident boasting about tomorrow and teaches us to say, "If the Lord is willing." God tells us to be still and know that He is God. Trusting the Lord with all our heart rather than leaning on our own understanding is not passivity; it is placing control in better hands. We are responsible for our choices, but the outcome belongs to God.

> *"A man's heart plans his course, but the LORD determines his steps"* (Proverbs 16:9).

Also see

> "Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and lean not on your own understanding; in all your ways acknowledge Him, and He will make your paths straight" (Proverbs 3:5–6).

> "'Be still and know that I am God; I will be exalted among the nations, I will be exalted over the earth.'" (Psalm 46:10).

> "Come now, you who say, 'Today or tomorrow we will go to this or that city, spend a year there, carry on business, and make a profit.' You do not even know what will happen tomorrow! What is your life? You are a mist that appears for a little while and then vanishes. Instead, you ought to say, 'If the Lord is willing, we will live and do this or that.'" (James 4:13–15).

> "Who of you by worrying can add a single hour to his life?" (Matthew 6:27).

Common self-statements

- If I don't handle it, it will fall apart.
- I can't stand not knowing what will happen.
- Others won't do it right.
- I have to plan for every possibility.
- Letting go feels dangerous.
- If I lose control, something bad will happen.

Common logical errors

- Catastrophizing: Believing disaster will follow if I loosen my grip.
- Should statements: Insisting things must go my way.
- Fortune telling: Predicting that others will fail if I don't manage them.
- Overestimating control: Thinking I can prevent outcomes that are really in God's hands.

Challenging questions

- When did I learn that I had to be in control?
- What am I actually able to control, and what not?
- What does my need for control cost me and others?
- What happens when I try to control things I cannot?
- What does God say about who directs my steps?
- What is one thing I could release to God this week?

Truth summary

> I am responsible for my own choices, and I can plan wisely. But I cannot control everything, and I don't have to. God directs my steps and holds what I cannot. I can do my part and trust Him with the rest.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Trust
- Plans
- Will of God
- Anxiety/Worry
- Peace

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Anxiety/Worry/Fear
- Prayer

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

What You Want — Tenth Avenue North
Following God involves trust and surrender without needing control of every outcome.

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Already There — Casting Crowns
God's perspective extends beyond what we can currently understand.

Turn Your Eyes Upon Jesus — Reawaken Hymns
This classic hymn directs attention to Christ when fear or earthly concerns dominate.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I must be in control"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I must be in control." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ When did I learn I had to be in control?
- ☐ What can I control and what not?
- ☐ What does control cost me?
- ☐ What happens when I try to control the uncontrollable?
- ☐ Who directs my steps?
- ☐ What can I release this week?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I plan, and the Lord directs my steps.
- ☐ I can be still and know He is God.
- ☐ I am responsible for my choices, not every outcome.
- ☐ Letting go is trusting, not giving up.
- ☐ God holds what I cannot.
- ☐ Worry cannot add an hour to my life.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Proverbs 16:9
  "A man's heart plans his course, but the LORD determines his steps."
- ☐ Proverbs 3:5–6
  "Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and lean not on your own understanding; in all your ways acknowledge Him, and He will make your paths straight."
- ☐ Psalm 46:10
  "'Be still and know that I am God; I will be exalted among the nations, I will be exalted over the earth.'"

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] What I released today: Each day, write one thing you tried to control and one thing you chose to release to God.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Proverbs 16:9 becomes: "Maria can write: "I can make my plans, but the Lord directs my steps. I can trust Him with the outcome.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Trust" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If this belief comes with hopelessness or thoughts of ending your life, call or text 988 (the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or call 911 in an emergency. You do not have to carry this alone.

- [ ] Draw the circle. Draw a circle. Inside, write what you can control. Outside, write what you can't. Pray over the outside list.
- [ ] Delegate one task. Let someone else do one task their way this week without correcting them.
- [ ] Practice uncertainty. Make one small plan with an open end, such as trying a new restaurant without reading reviews.
- [ ] Pray a release prayer. Each morning, name one worry and say, "Lord, I give this to You."

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I must be in control": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Something I released
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I must be in control.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I hold on so tightly because I am afraid. Thank You that You direct my steps and hold what I cannot. Help me do my part, release the rest, and rest in Your care. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.